

UK Stay & PR Options Guide

For international graduates facing a finished Graduate/PSW visa, no sponsorship, or ended sponsorship

Why this guide exists

Many international graduates reach the same difficult point: the Graduate (formerly PSW) visa is ending, an employer will not sponsor them, or an existing sponsored job has ended. The key is to separate work-route solutions, family/private-life solutions and a fee-waiver request. A fee waiver does not create immigration permission by itself.

Graduate / PSW finished

The Graduate visa cannot be extended. The normal next step is another eligible route, such as Skilled Worker, if the applicant qualifies.

No sponsorship

FLR or a fee waiver is not a substitute for sponsorship. First assess Skilled Worker and genuinely available alternative routes.

Sponsorship ended

A sponsored worker may face cancellation/curtailment. A replacement sponsor may be needed within the actual Home Office deadline.

The most important rule

Do not choose a route only because it is cheaper or because someone calls it “FLR”. The correct route depends on current status, expiry/curtailment date, job and salary, family/private-life facts, residence history and eligibility for another route.

This guide follows the clean section/card/roadmap structure of the supplied Nova Scotia PR reference, adapted for UK stay and immigration decision-making.

1. FLR, Fee Waiver, Graduate Visa & Sponsorship

Graduate Visa (PSW)

Temporary post-study route. GOV.UK confirms it cannot be extended. It can sometimes be followed by another route. Applications made on/before 31 Dec 2026 generally receive 2 years; from 1 Jan 2027 the standard period becomes 18 months. Doctoral graduates remain eligible for 3 years.

Sponsorship / CoS

Skilled Worker normally requires a qualifying job with an eligible licensed sponsor and a valid Certificate of Sponsorship (CoS), plus the route's salary and other requirements.

FLR — Further Leave to Remain

FLR is not one universal visa. It is used for certain in-country applications, including family/private-life routes. The underlying legal route must be established. Grant of FLR normally gives temporary permission, not automatic PR/ILR.

Fee Waiver

Not a visa. It is a request to waive an eligible immigration application fee and/or IHS because the applicant cannot afford it. It does not create a sponsor, CoS or immigration route.

FLR vs Fee Waiver

Point	FLR / relevant leave application	Fee Waiver
Meaning	Application for permission to stay under a specific route.	Request to waive an eligible fee and/or IHS.
Visa?	Can result in temporary permission if the underlying route is granted.	No. It is not immigration permission.
Purpose	Obtain/extend permission to remain.	Address inability to afford eligible costs.
Application fee	£1,407 for the 8 Apr 2026 "Leave to remain - Other" fee; route-specific rules still apply.	£0 for the amount successfully waived.
IHS	Usually payable where applicable.	May also be waived where eligibility is established.
Fix no sponsorship?	No. Underlying family/private-life basis is required.	No. Cannot create sponsorship or CoS.
PR immediately?	Generally no; temporary leave unless applying for settlement.	No. Only addresses eligible fees.

Common mistake: "PSW finished → apply FLR → wait for sponsorship." This is not a general legal pathway. The applicant must qualify for the underlying FLR/family/private-life route, while a Skilled Worker applicant must still obtain a qualifying sponsor and CoS.

2. 2026 Costs + Which Option Should Be Assessed First?

Route / item	2026 fee	Key point
Leave to remain - Other	£1,407	Generic in-country fee category; match the actual application to the correct route.
Family visa - in UK	£1,407	GOV.UK in-country family application fee.
Graduate Route - in UK	£937	Application fee; Graduate route cannot be extended.
Skilled Worker - up to 3 years, in UK	£943	Longer applications cost more; Health and Care cases can have reduced fees.
Skilled Worker - over 3 years, in UK	£1,865	Application fee only; IHS separate where applicable.
Global Talent - in UK	£766	Usually includes endorsement fee + visa fee structure.
Scale-up - in UK	£937	Only if route eligibility is met.
HPI - in UK	£880	Only if university, qualification and timing requirements are met.
IHS - most adults	£1,035/year	Students/under-18 applicants generally have lower rates. Exact amount depends on visa length/circumstances.

Example

£1,407 application + £1,035 one-year adult IHS = £2,442. A longer IHS period can increase the total. If an eligible fee waiver is approved, the application fee, IHS or both may be waived depending on the circumstances.

Decision matrix

Situation	First option to assess	Main warning
PSW ending soon	Skilled Worker / other qualifying route	Graduate visa cannot be extended. Start the next-route assessment early.
PSW already finished	Urgent status + route audit	Check exact expiry, in-time applications and any overstay issue.
Employer refuses sponsorship	Different licensed sponsor / alternative route	Fee waiver cannot replace a sponsor or CoS.
Sponsored job ended	New sponsor before actual deadline	Check the curtailment notice; do not rely on a generic deadline.
Family/private-life + cannot afford fees	Fee waiver + correct underlying application	Both the underlying route and finances must be supported.
Possible 10-year lawful residence	Long Residence / ILR assessment	Check continuity, absences, breaks and current rules.

Alternative routes

Global Talent: for applicants meeting talent/endorsement or qualifying-prize requirements. Scale-up: where the applicant qualifies for the route and an eligible job/sponsorship arrangement. HPI: for eligible graduates of qualifying overseas universities who meet the timing rules.

3. FLR / Private Life & Fee Waiver — Evidence and Timing

Start with the underlying route. The first question is not “Can we get a fee waiver?” but “What immigration route is the applicant actually entitled to apply under?” Private Life and family routes have their own requirements; a fee waiver does not create eligibility.

Evidence area	What to organise	Why it matters
Immigration history	Visas, eVisa/status records, expiry dates, applications, decisions, curtailment letters.	Determines current status, deadlines and possible section 3C issues.
Identity	Passport, eVisa/BRP details and Home Office correspondence.	Supports the application and status assessment.
Family/private life	Relationships, residence history, children’s circumstances and relevant hardship/integration evidence.	Supports the underlying route—not simply the fee waiver.
Financial position	Bank statements, payslips, income/benefits evidence, rent, bills, debts, essential spending and support received.	Fee-waiver assessment focuses on genuine ability/inability to pay.
Accommodation / essentials	Tenancy, rent, utilities, food/heating costs and evidence of inability to meet essentials where relevant.	Can be relevant to inability to afford the fee/IHS.

Fee Waiver — practical decision logic

- Underlying application eligible? Establish this first.
- Can the applicant pay? Evidence must show actual financial circumstances, not simply lack of cash on one particular day.
- Fee + IHS: the assessment may cover the application fee and/or IHS depending on circumstances.
- Section 3C: for eligible fee-waiver situations, Home Office guidance provides protection where the person had valid permission when the fee-waiver request was made, permission expires while the request is pending, and the valid underlying application is submitted within 10 working days of the fee-waiver decision.

Critical: A fee waiver is not a “10-day visa extension”. If the required follow-up application is not submitted correctly and on time, the protective effect can fail. Always check the actual dates and Home Office correspondence.

When professional review is especially important

Overstaying, previous refusals, curtailment, sponsor revocation, deception allegations, criminality or complicated family/private-life facts should be reviewed by a regulated immigration professional rather than handled from a generic FLR/fee-waiver checklist.

4. Client Roadmap — From Problem to Best Viable Option

Step	Action	What to check
1	Confirm status	Visa type, eVisa/status, expiry date, curtailment notice and previous applications.
2	Calculate deadline	Actual expiry/curtailment date; any fee-waiver or application reference and submission date.
3	Screen Skilled Worker	Occupation, salary, licensed sponsor, CoS and route requirements.
4	Screen alternatives	Global Talent, Scale-up, HPI or another route only if genuinely eligible.
5	Screen family/private life	Use FLR/private-life strategy only where the facts support the Immigration Rules.
6	Assess affordability	If the underlying route is fee-waiver eligible, prepare a detailed financial evidence pack.
7	Protect timing	Follow fee-waiver procedure precisely; where relevant, submit the underlying application within the required period.
8	Escalate complex cases	Use regulated professional advice for high-risk or unusual cases.

Bottom line

Best viable option = the route the applicant genuinely qualifies for, not simply the route with the lowest fee. PSW/Graduate ending → assess Skilled Worker/other qualifying routes. Sponsored job ended → check curtailment and replacement sponsorship. Genuine family/private-life case + unaffordable fee → consider fee waiver with the correct underlying application. FLR and Fee Waiver are not competing visas; they solve different problems.

Official sources

[Home Office immigration & nationality fees — 8 April 2026](#)

[Graduate visa](#)

[Skilled Worker visa](#)

[Fee waiver guidance](#)

[IHS rates](#)

[Appendix Private Life](#)

[Family visas](#)

[Cancellation / curtailment guidance](#)

Disclaimer: Educational/marketing reference only; not legal advice or a guarantee of outcome. UK immigration rules, fees and eligibility can change. Verify current GOV.UK rules and obtain regulated advice for complex/high-risk cases.